STIVEN CATALYST

SECOND SERIES · NOVEMBER 2026

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



ROLE

MENTOR AND SPONSOR

Kram's two kinds of help, high potentials who were mentored but not promoted, what a sponsor does that a mentor does not, what the meta-analyses find, assigned or chosen mentors, and a card for one relationship.

72% of the men with an active mentor in 2008 had been promoted at least once by 2010; of the women, 65%.

IBARRA, CARTER & SILVA, 2010

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NO. 72 · ROLE

In this issue

Most people who move up can name someone who helped them. Two kinds of help are often mixed up: a mentor talks with you about your work, a sponsor talks about you where decisions are made. Here the two are taken apart, with what each is worth.

Kathy Kram described what mentors give: career help, sponsorship among it, and personal support. In a Catalyst survey of more than 4,000 high potentials, more women than men had mentors, yet fewer of the mentored women were promoted. Two meta-analyses find mentoring linked with better careers, but with small effects on pay and promotion. People who found their mentors themselves did better than those who were assigned one, and in formal programmes a say in the process and good training made a difference.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Two kinds of help

Kathy Kram studied 18 pairs of junior and senior managers in mentoring relationships, and in Mentoring at Work (1985) she sorted what mentors do into two groups: help with the career, and help with the person.

Career functions	Psychosocial functions
Sponsorship	Role modelling
Exposure and visibility	Acceptance and confirmation
Coaching	Counselling
Protection	Friendship
Challenging assignments	

Twenty-five years later, Herminia Ibarra, Nancy Carter and Christine Silva met a senior marketing manager who had been matched with a high-level mentor and invited to a programme for high potentials:

> “I'd been here for 12 years, and nothing happened. Now I am being mentored to death.”

OUR READING

A mentor talks with you. A sponsor talks about you, in rooms you are not in.

Sources: Kathy E. Kram, Scott, Foresman, 1985 (via Kram & Isabella, 1985; Allen et al., 2004; Ibarra, Carter & Silva, 2010); Kathy E. Kram & Lynn A. Isabella, Academy of Management Journal 28(1), 1985; Herminia Ibarra, Nancy M. Carter & Christine Silva, Harvard Business Review, 2010

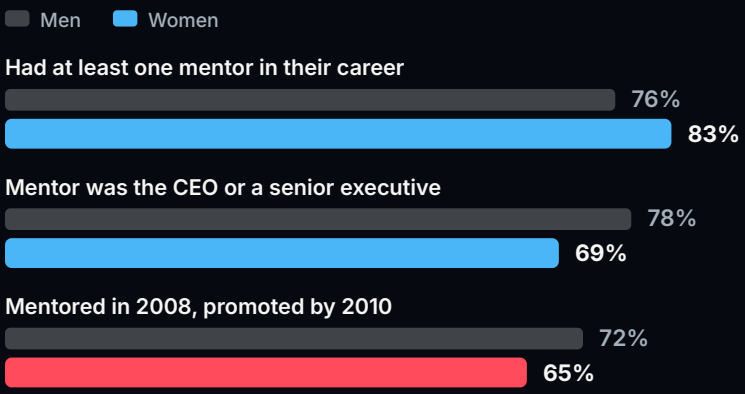
The functions as Kram and Isabella list them (1985); the 18 pairs are Kram's earlier interview study. We could not see the book itself. The authors disguised the manager's name.

THE NUMBERS

Mentored, not promoted

In 2008 Catalyst surveyed more than 4,000 high potentials who had graduated from top MBA programmes worldwide between 1996 and 2007. In 2010 it asked the same group about promotions since.

HIGH POTENTIALS IN THE CATALYST SURVEYS, 2008 AND 2010



The women's mentors were less senior, even allowing for their lower starting posts, and the more senior the mentor, the faster the advancement. Both made as many lateral moves, but the men were promoted after them. By 2010 the men had 15% more promotions.

OUR READING

The gap stayed open despite more advice. The women lacked someone senior to vouch for them.

Source: Herminia Ibarra, Nancy M. Carter & Christine Silva, Harvard Business Review, 2010

Self-reports; rows two and three cover those with an active mentor in 2008. A survey shows links, not causes; mentoring predicted promotion for the men, not for the women.

THE MODEL

Mentor and sponsor

Ibarra and her co-authors define sponsorship as a relationship in which the mentor goes beyond feedback and advice and uses influence with senior executives to advocate for the person. In Kram's terms it is one of five career functions; the authors found it was what the women lacked.

Mentors	Sponsors
can sit at any level	are senior and have influence
give support, feedback and advice	introduce you to other executives
serve as role models	put your name forward for openings
help read company politics	fight for your promotion

THE FOUR PHASES OF A MENTORING RELATIONSHIP (KRAM)

01	02	03	04
Initiation	Cultivation	Separation	Redefinition

OUR READING

A sponsor lends you a reputation, and lends it on the strength of what they have seen you do.

Sources: Herminia Ibarra, Nancy M. Carter & Christine Silva, Harvard Business Review, 2010; Kathy E. Kram & Lynn A. Isabella, Academy of Management Journal 28(1), 1985

The two lists shorten the table in Ibarra et al. (2010). The phases follow Kram (1983) as Kram and Isabella summarise them: in cultivation the help is at its widest; after separation, much of it stops.

More in the essay Starting from zero after you have led people and a business

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

What mentoring is worth

Tammy Allen and colleagues pooled the studies on what mentoring brings the person mentored. The benefits held up, but effects on pay and promotion were small.



In 2008 Lillian Eby and colleagues pooled 116 samples from youth, academic and workplace mentoring: many outcomes were better, but the effects were generally small.

OUR READING

Support makes people like their mentor. Pay and promotion move, a little, with the career help.

Sources: Tammy D. Allen, Lillian T. Eby, Mark L. Poteet, Elizabeth Lentz & Lizzette Lima, Journal of Applied Psychology 89(1), 2004; Lillian T. Eby, Tammy D. Allen, Sarah C. Evans, Thomas Ng & David L. DuBois, Journal of Vocational Behavior 72(2), 2008

r runs from −1 to 1, with 0 for no link; Eby et al. count 0.10 to 0.23 as small. Mostly surveys at one point in time: they show links, not causes.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Assigned or chosen

Belle Rose Ragins and John Cotton asked US engineers, social workers and journalists about their mentors and counted promotions over ten years. Of 1,162 respondents, 44% had an informal mentor, 9% a formal one and 47% none.

PROMOTIONS IN TEN YEARS, ON AVERAGE (1999)



Only those with informal mentors were promoted significantly more, and earned more, than people without one; those with assigned mentors did not differ from them. In formal programmes, Allen, Eby and Lentz (2006) found two features linked with better mentoring: a say in the process, and training judged good.

OUR READING

A programme can arrange the meeting; the sponsor's interest has to be earned. Who senior to you has actually seen your work this year?

Sources: Belle Rose Ragins & John L. Cotton, Journal of Applied Psychology 84(4), 1999; Tammy D. Allen, Lillian T. Eby & Elizabeth Lentz, Journal of Applied Psychology 91(3), 2006

A promotion counted with at least two of: a significant raise, wider responsibility, a higher level, eligibility for bonuses. The authors warn of selection: people who find mentors themselves may be stronger to begin with.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The mentor and sponsor card

One card per relationship. Write down which help you are asking for, advice or a word in the right room, and when you will check that it came. When a name is put forward, the CV has to be ready.

01 The goal one: a skill, a role, a move within a year

02 What the mentor gives advice, feedback, an example: which, and on what

03 What the sponsor risks whose name, in front of whom, and what they have seen you do

04 The next opportunity a role, a project or a meeting, and who decides it

05 How often when you meet, and who asks for the meeting

06 Review date what has opened, and whether to go on, change or end

Sources: Herminia Ibarra, Nancy M. Carter & Christine Silva, Harvard Business Review, 2010; Kathy E. Kram & Lynn A. Isabella, Academy of Management Journal 28(1), 1985; Tammy D. Allen, Lillian T. Eby & Elizabeth Lentz, Journal of Applied Psychology 91(3), 2006

Proposed by the editors. It draws on the mentor and sponsor roles in Ibarra et al. (2010), Kram's phases and the say in the process that Allen, Eby and Lentz (2006) found mattered.

Open the tool: CV Builder stivencatalyst.com/tools/cv-builder/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Mentoring at Work: Developmental Relationships in Organizational Life
Kathy E. Kram, Scott, Foresman, 1985 · via Kram & Isabella, 1985; Allen et al., 2004; Ibarra, Carter & Silva, 2010

Mentoring Alternatives: The Role of Peer Relationships in Career Development
Kathy E. Kram & Lynn A. Isabella, Academy of Management Journal 28(1), 1985
https://doi.org/10.5465/256064

Why Men Still Get More Promotions Than Women
Herminia Ibarra, Nancy M. Carter & Christine Silva, Harvard Business Review, 2010
https://hbr.org/2010/09/why-men-still-get-more-promotions-than-women

Career Benefits Associated With Mentoring for Protégés: A Meta-Analysis
Tammy D. Allen, Lillian T. Eby, Mark L. Poteet, Elizabeth Lentz & Lizzette Lima, Journal of Applied Psychology 89(1), 2004
https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.89.1.127

Does Mentoring Matter? A Multidisciplinary Meta-Analysis Comparing Mentored and Non-Mentored Individuals
Lillian T. Eby, Tammy D. Allen, Sarah C. Evans, Thomas Ng & David L. DuBois, Journal of Vocational Behavior 72(2), 2008
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jvb.2007.04.005

Mentor Functions and Outcomes: A Comparison of Men and Women in Formal and Informal Mentoring Relationships
Belle Rose Ragins & John L. Cotton, Journal of Applied Psychology 84(4), 1999
https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.84.4.529

Mentorship Behaviors and Mentorship Quality Associated With Formal Mentoring Programs: Closing the Gap Between Research and Practice
Tammy D. Allen, Lillian T. Eby & Elizabeth Lentz, Journal of Applied Psychology 91(3), 2006
https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.91.3.567

CORRECTION · 13 OCTOBER 2026

Lillian Eby and colleagues (2008) pooled samples from youth, academic and workplace mentoring; the text first said school mentoring instead of academic.

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

Management Review · No. 72 · November 2026 · Stiven Catalyst